electrification. Now we are taking it to the next level by ensuring 100% electrification of every household.'[116]

The BJP also makes much of the fact that the Ministry of Development of North Eastern Region was established by the first Vajpayee government in 2001. The funding for this ministry increased by 14 per cent in 2020-21 (from ₹2,670 crore in 2019-20 to ₹3,049 crore), which shows how important the Modi government considers it. In fact, government data shows that actual expenditure on gross budgetary support to the north-eastern states in fifty-four ministries rose by 142 per cent (from ₹23,819 crore to ₹60,112 crore) between 2014-15 and 2020-21. Simultaneously, the budget for the North Eastern Council doubled between 2015 and 2020, from ₹700 crore to ₹1,747 crore.[117]

Government data shows that Central government funding for most states in the region increased significantly between 2014-15 and 2018-19. In Assam, where the BJP formed its first government in 2016, central funding increased by over fifty per cent in this period, in Manipur by over sixty-six per cent, and it more than doubled in Mizoram (see Table 16.7).

Being in power at the Centre clearly increased the BJP's bargaining power in the Northeast. Regional parties and influential local politicians began to see the benefit of aligning with the BJP, just as they had seen the benefits of doing so with the Congress in the days of its hegemony. The BJP combined this advantage with its aggressive ground campaigning, tactical alliances and messaging on the narrative of development fronted by Prime Minister Modi.

Table 16.7: Increases in Central Funding for North-eastern States (2014–2019)*